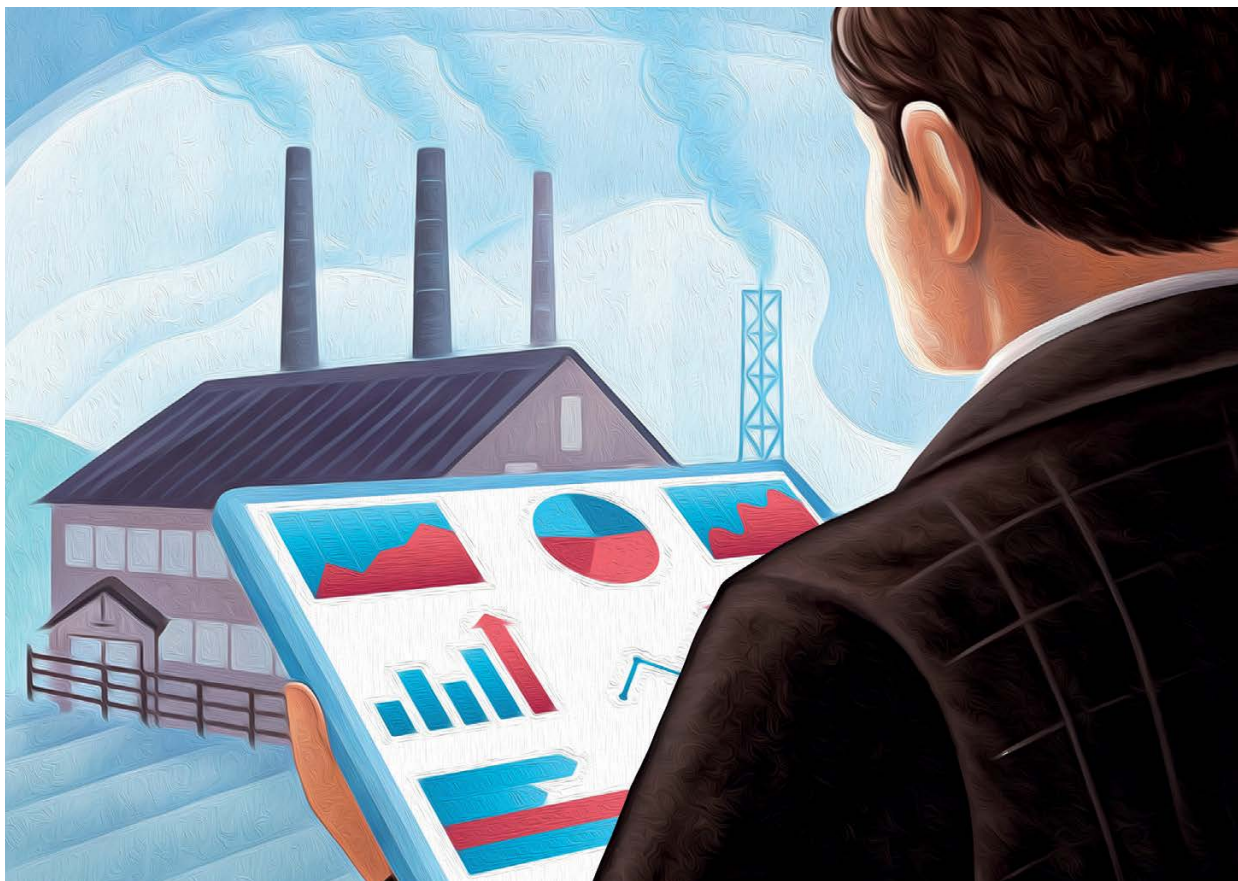



ILLUSTRATION BY **RAJ VERMA**

securing the nation. Instead of focussing solely on industrialisation to ensure long-term economic security, it also considers food, health, technology and skills security as critical dimensions. Building on the initiatives announced in the previous Budget, this year's Budget promises to build five National Centres of Excellence to equip the youth with the skills required to 'Make in India'.

The Budget has also announced a Deep Tech Fund of Funds and has allocated ₹500 crore to set up a Centre of Excellence in Artificial Intelligence. The proposed national framework to promote Global Capability Centres in emerging Tier II cities will also go a long way towards deepening skill development beyond Indian metros. Contributions from the private sector and

global players will be imperative.

The government also announced an ₹20,000 crore fund for private sector driven R&D and innovation—a big step towards creating enablement and skilling support. Additionally, the gene bank, high-yield seeds, creative urban planning and even research scholarships reiterate the strong push for innovation.

Over the years, India's limitations in terms of ease of doing business (EoDB) have been highlighted by domestic and international players—and it is heartening to see the Budget highlighting reforms to address this challenge. However, the newly proposed High-Level Committee for Regulatory Reforms has its task cut out—beyond reviewing regulations, certifications, licences and permissions, it must establish ef-

fective change management mechanisms for regulators, businesses and citizens to ensure that this focus on EoDB and trust-based governance translates from policy to practice.

The 2025-26 Budget demonstrates the government's willingness to make strategic investments from a position of fiscal strength, which has been achieved despite challenges. With supportive reforms and expectations of an easing monetary policy, we could expect the private investment cycle to pick up. Leveraging the impetus from this Budget, businesses must foster innovation and build capacity, positioning themselves and the nation as a formidable and stable economic centre on the world stage. **BT**

Views are personal